

SC.4 Where to File Directory

Which office has your parcel, the offices beyond the building department, and a page to record what you confirmed.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. South Carolina is a mandatory-enforcement state: § 6-9-10 orders every municipality and county to enforce the state code, and to enforce *only* that code, so the question that dominates most states in this series — will anyone inspect this house? — has a statutory answer here. What South Carolina replaces it with is a stack of small obligations with hard consequences: a disclosure you sign in person, a notice you file at the register of deeds afterwards, an energy code fixed by statute rather than by the code council, and a coastline the law forbids anyone to describe county by county. Fees, portals, review queues and the extra permits your particular lot triggers still vary. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it.

FIRST, ESTABLISH WHO ACTUALLY HAS YOUR PARCEL

South Carolina answers the “does anyone permit out here?” question in statute: § 6-9-10(A) requires all municipalities and counties to enforce the codes, and § 6-9-30(A) requires each county to appoint a building official “so that the unincorporated area of the county is under the jurisdiction of a building official.” There is no general unincorporated gap here. **Assume a permit is required everywhere in South Carolina.**

The live question is therefore *which* office, and the answer turns on one thing: **are you inside a municipality's limits?** If you are, the city or town issues your permit and the county does not. Annexed parcels on the fringes of Greenville, Columbia, Charleston, Rock Hill, Bluffton and Fort Mill are where owner-builders most often apply to the wrong office and lose weeks. Check the parcel against your county's GIS viewer before you fill anything in, and if the boundary is ambiguous, ask both offices in writing.

There is one lawful way out of enforcement, and no public list of who used it

Section 6-9-30(B) lets a municipality or county that “determines that it is unable to arrange for services for any annual period at costs totally within the schedule of fees recommended in the appendices to the building codes” submit an affidavit to the Building Codes Council and be “exempt from the requirements of this chapter” for up to five years, renewable. It is a financial-hardship escape, and it is real law.

The Council does not publish a roster of who currently holds one. So if a rural office tells you it does not issue building permits, do not just accept it and do not assume it is wrong: ask whether the jurisdiction has filed a § 6-9-30(B) affidavit, and get the answer in writing. Your lender, your insurer and your eventual buyer will all ask the same question.

THE OFFICES BEYOND THE BUILDING DEPARTMENT

Nine offices that are not your building department

	What it does and how to find it	Who
Register of deeds	Where the notice that keeps your exemption alive is recorded, indexed under your name in the grantor's index (§ 40-59-260(E)). County-level office; some counties combine it with the clerk of court.	Your county
Clerk of court	Where a Notice of Project Commencement is filed if you use one — fifteen days, \$15 (§ 29-5-23). Either office takes it; ask yours which.	Your county
Septic	des.sc.gov → Permits & Regulations → Septic Tanks. The agency also publishes homeowner resources, a “before you buy land” page and an e-permitting route.	SCDES
Private wells	des.sc.gov → Programs → Bureau of Water → Residential Wells. Same agency as septic, different bureau — and there is a separate coastal plain well map at gis.des.sc.gov .	SCDES
Coastal critical area, beachfront	des.sc.gov → Programs → Bureau of Coastal Management → Critical Area Permitting, or Beachfront Management. This is the office guides still call OCRM.	SCDES
Termite treatment regulation	The state code's added termite treatment route is enforced by the Clemson University Department of Pesticide Regulation (R.8-1215) — neither your building department nor a health agency.	Clemson
Contractor license lookup	llr.sc.gov → Licensee Lookup. Covers both residential builders and residential specialty licensees and registrants. Use it before you pay anyone more than \$500.	SC LLR
Code editions and amendments	scstatehouse.gov/coderegs/ → Chapter 8. Not the Building Codes Council's own Codes page, which still serves a 2019 scan of the previous edition.	State
Road access	Whoever maintains the road you are connecting to. Several counties — Pickens among them — point residents at a state encroachment permit for driveways off state-maintained roads.	Varies

Three dead ends that are still in circulation

scdhec.gov serves nothing. The Department of Health and Environmental Control was split; environmental programs went to the Department of Environmental Services at **des.sc.gov** and public health to the Department of Public Health at **dph.sc.gov**. The old domain was not redirected — it simply fails. County pages at Anderson, Oconee, York, Georgetown, Horry and Kershaw were still linking septic guidance to it in September 2026. Pickens and Berkeley had updated theirs.

OCRM is a retired brand. Coastal work is the Bureau of Coastal Management inside SCDES. A guide that tells you to file with OCRM is telling you the right thing under the wrong name — but it also tells you how old the guide is.

laurenscounty.us is not Laurens County. The legacy domain now redirects to an unrelated commercial medical practice. The county is at **laurenscountysc.gov**. Several other counties have moved to .gov hosts and left working redirects behind — Charleston, Spartanburg, York, Florence, Sumter, Lancaster and Georgetown — but this one did not.

COUNTY BUILDING OFFICES

Hosts and navigation, not deep links — see the note at the foot of this document for why. All confirmed September 2026.

Twenty counties, confirmed September 2026

County	Office name	Where to look	Portal
Aiken	Planning & Development	aikencountysc.gov	Citizenserve
Anderson	Building & Codes	andersoncountysc.org	OpenGov
Beaufort	Building Inspections	beaufortcountysc.gov → Building Codes	None found
Berkeley	Building and Codes Enforcement	berkeleycountysc.gov → Permitting	County-run
Charleston	Building Inspection Services	charlestoncounty.gov	Tyler EnerGov
Dorchester	Building Services	dorchestercountysc.gov	InfoVision Evolve
Florence	Planning	florencecountysc.gov → Planning	County-hosted
Georgetown	Building Department	gtcountysc.gov	None found
Greenville	Building Safety	greenvillecounty.org → Building Safety	eTRAKiT
Horry	Code Enforcement	horrycountysc.gov	Tyler EnerGov
Kershaw	Building Permits and Inspections	kershaw.sc.gov → Planning & Zoning	None found
Lancaster	Development Services	lancastercountysc.gov	InfoVision Evolve
Laurens	Building Codes	laurenscountysc.gov	None found
Lexington	Building Permits	lex-co.sc.gov → Community Development	CityView / BluePrince

Twenty counties, confirmed September 2026

County	Office name	Where to look	Portal
Oconee	Building Codes	oconeesc.com	Citizenserve
Pickens	Building Codes	co.pickens.sc.us	Tyler EnerGov
Richland	Building Permitting and Inspections	richlandcountysc.gov	eTRAKiT
Spartanburg	Building Codes	spartanburgcounty.gov	Tyler EnerGov
Sumter	Building Inspections	sumtercountysc.gov	None found
York	Building & Codes	yorkcountysc.gov	None found

South Carolina has 46 counties. The twenty above are where most owner-building happens and are the ones this kit verified page by page. For any other county, search for the county name plus “building codes” and check that the host ends in a South Carolina government domain before you trust the page — several counties have live legacy hosts, and at least one legacy host now belongs to somebody else entirely.

CITIES AND TOWNS THAT ISSUE THEIR OWN PERMITS

If your lot is inside these limits, apply here and not to the county.

Fifteen municipalities, confirmed September 2026

City or town	Where to look	Portal
Aiken	cityofaikensc.gov → Permitting & Codes	None evident
Charleston	charleston-sc.gov → Permit Center	Tyler EnerGov
Columbia	columbiasc.gov → Planning and Development Services	Tyler EnerGov
Florence	cityofflorencesc.gov → Building Department	None — in person or email
Goose Creek	goosecreeksc.gov → Building Permits	OpenGov
Greenville	greenvillesc.gov → Building Permit Center	City e-forms plus a service center
Hilton Head Island	hiltonheadislandsc.gov → Building Permits	Tyler EnerGov
Mount Pleasant	tompssc.com → Building and Permit Center	OPAL
Myrtle Beach	cityofmyrtlebeach.com → Construction Services	None — email or file share
North Charleston	northcharleston.org → Construction and Development	City-hosted
North Myrtle Beach	nmb.us → Planning & Development	OpenGov

Fifteen municipalities, confirmed September 2026

City or town	Where to look	Portal
Rock Hill	cityofrockhill.com → Permits & Inspections	None for permits
Spartanburg	cityofspartanburg.org → Building Permits	Commercial plan review only
Summerville	summervillesc.gov → Permitting	Citizenserve
Sumter	sumtersc.gov → Permits	None evident

*Two cautions. **Rock Hill and Greenville County both publish OpenGov links that are procurement portals — bids and requests for proposals — not permit portals.** And the City of Sumter is a different office from Sumter County; so are the City of Charleston and Charleston County, the City of Greenville and Greenville County, the City of Spartanburg and Spartanburg County, the City of Florence and Florence County, and the City of Aiken and Aiken County. Five of South Carolina's busiest permitting relationships are city-and-county pairs sharing a name.*

WHICH OFFICES PUBLISH AN OWNER-BUILDER FORM

Every one of these is a local rendering of the same statute — § 40-59-260 — so if yours is not listed, ask for it by the name the statute uses: the **disclosure statement** the permitting agency must provide, and the **register-of-deeds notice** forms it must hand you at the same visit. Where a jurisdiction has published one, its own wording is worth reading, because several of them add requirements the statute does not state.

Published owner-builder documents, and what each one adds

	What they publish
Greenville County	"Owner Builder Disclosure Statement." The county requires it notarized and recorded before it is submitted.
Richland County	"Statement of Disclosure." Must be notarized and filed with the Register of Deeds. Bring a copy of the property plat.
Charleston County	"Unlicensed Residential Builder's Disclosure Statement," headed as an acknowledgment under § 40-59-260(E). Notarized, two witnesses, and recorded as a condition of approving the permit application. Adds "direct, on-site supervision" and bars homeowners from pulling permits for work on a manufactured home.
Oconee County	"Owner/Builder Disclosure." The county also publishes a "Work Exempt From Permit" list, a site plan checklist and a farm structure affidavit.
Anderson County	An owner-builder subcontractor listing — the document where you name the licensed trades on your job.
City of Columbia	"Homeowner Affidavit / Homeowner-Occupant Work Permit Certification." States the register-of-deeds requirement and that failure to file revokes the exemption.

Published owner-builder documents, and what each one adds

	What they publish
Hilton Head Island	"Unlicensed Residential Builder's Disclosure Statement" — submitted to Beaufort County, not to the town.
City of Sumter	Requires the owner/builder affidavit to be recorded with the Sumter County Register of Deeds before a building permit can be obtained. The form is the county's, not the city's.
City of Aiken	A homeowners' question-and-answer page rather than a form — and the clearest published local statement that an owner may do their own building, plumbing, electrical and mechanical work on their own house, subject to the two-year rule, personal supervision, and the register-of-deeds filing.
Kershaw County	No owner-builder form, but publishes an "Affidavit of Construction of a Farm Structure" — the § 6-9-65 filing that has to happen <i>before</i> you build the barn.

The online-only county and the personal-appearance statute

Greenville County states that "All permits must be submitted through eTrakit." Spartanburg County's own building permits link redirects straight into its portal. The City of Greenville runs entirely on electronic forms.

But § 40-59-260(C) says an owner claiming the exemption "must personally appear and sign the building permit application," and (D) says the agency must hand you the register-of-deeds forms when you do. **Do not assume you can complete an owner-builder permit entirely online anywhere in South Carolina.** Ask the office how it reconciles its portal with the personal-appearance requirement, and book the visit.

OFFICES I CONFIRMED

Fill this in as you go. It is the page worth having on the job when somebody asks who approved what.

My offices

	Item	Date	Confirmed
☐	Building department — jurisdiction and office name Office _____		
☐	Confirmed my parcel is inside / outside municipal limits Which _____		
☐	Portal name and my account set up Portal _____		

My offices

	Item	Date	Confirmed
☐	Register of deeds — and whether the notice records before the permit or after completion Which _____		
☐	Clerk of court, if the Notice of Project Commencement goes there Office _____		
☐	Zoning contact and the setbacks confirmed for this parcel Front / side / rear _____		
☐	Septic — SCDES office or authorized agent handling my application Contact _____		
☐	Well — SCDES bureau contact, if drilling Contact _____		
☐	Coastal critical area or beachfront — needed? who confirmed? Yes / No _____ Confirmed by _____		
☐	Road authority for my driveway connection Authority _____		
☐	Stormwater or land disturbance contact, if disturbing one acre or more Contact _____		
☐	Utility providers — power, water, gas — and what each needs before connection Providers _____		
☐	Termite treatment provider and who issues the record Provider _____		

SOURCES

Sources — every South Carolina claim in this document (verified September 2026)

What this document states	Authority
Enforcement is mandatory in every municipality and county; each county must place its unincorporated area under a building official	S.C. Code Ann. § 6-9-10(A), § 6-9-30(A)
The financial-hardship affidavit that exempts a jurisdiction from the chapter	S.C. Code Ann. § 6-9-30(B)
The register-of-deeds notice, the disclosure statement, and the agency's duty to hand over the forms	S.C. Code Ann. § 40-59-260(C), (D), (E)
Notice of Project Commencement goes to the clerk of court or the register of deeds	S.C. Code Ann. § 29-5-23
Farm structure affidavit must be filed before construction	S.C. Code Ann. § 6-9-65
Termite treatment route enforced by the Clemson University Department of Pesticide Regulation	S.C. Code of Regs. 8-1215
Septic, private wells, and coastal critical area and beachfront authorization	SCDES, des.sc.gov
Contractor and specialty credential lookup	SC LLR, llr.sc.gov
Every county and city office named here	Fetches September 2026

This directory prints hosts and navigation paths instead of deep links on purpose. South Carolina counties have moved hosts in numbers — charlestoncounty.org, spartanburgcounty.org, yorkcountygov.com, florenceco.org, sumtercountysc.org, mylancastersc.org and gtcounty.org have all been superseded — and the numeric page identifiers many county sites use are recycled between departments, so a printed link can quietly land on the wrong office. A host plus a menu path survives both. Everything here was fetched and content-confirmed in September 2026; confirm anything that matters with the office itself.